

Narrative transportation: A systematic literature review and future research agenda

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Abstract

Consumers are inundated with opportunities to become engaged with marketing-generated stories, from watching an influencer detail her adventures abroad or a commercial about a military service member who makes it home just in time for the holidays. When consumers become so engaged with a story that they begin to connect with the story characters and imagine what will happen next, they experience a process known as narrative transportation, which has significant positive outcomes for marketers. Given the value that narrative transportation provides to marketers, we conduct a systematic literature review to both synthesize and provide direction on the literature of narrative transportation. From our analysis of 95 peer-reviewed articles, we identify relevant theoretical foundations and concepts (antecedents, outcomes, and moderators) employed in these articles. Using these results as our foundation, we detail how narrative transportation has evolved in terms of both the presentation of the story and the antecedents that affect narrative transportation. Further, we present a conceptual model that will represent the next iteration of the narrative transportation framework and suggest avenues for future research. In doing so, we enable researchers to continue the exploration of the narrative transportation construct.

KEYWORDS

narrative transportation, persuasion, storytelling, systematic literature review

1 | INTRODUCTION

Boy meets girl. Boy and girl fall in love. Boy and girl live happily ever after. It is a familiar story that has been conveyed in texts, films, and even commercials. Sometimes this story is so compelling that we find ourselves wrapped up in the moment, laughing, cringing, crying, and rejoicing with and for the characters. We become completely transported into this tale of love, grief, or heartache, to the point that the story world can feel just as real and as captivating as everyday life. Storytelling is powerful, taking us to story worlds through a process known as narrative transportation, whereby the

audience becomes immersed in the story such that they begin to imagine the story environment and empathize with the story characters (Green & Brock, 2000).

While initially explored from the perspective of a story's ability to captivate its audience (Gerrig, 1993), researchers, across multiple disciplines and contexts, have started to focus on narrative transportation as a means by which to persuade, influencing change in consumers' attitudes, thoughts, intentions, and behaviors (e.g., van Laer et al., 2014). While the varied interest in narrative transportation as a persuasive mechanism is exciting, it has resulted in fragmented discourse with relevant research appearing in journals specific to

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disciplines such as advertising (Grigsby et al., 2023), marketing (Anaza et al., 2020), communications (Oh et al., 2020), psychology (Nielsen et al., 2018), and healthcare (Andrews et al., 2022). Given the value that narrative transportation provides to marketers in terms of influencing product choice (Redondo et al., 2018), improving attitudes (Escalas, 2004), enhancing word-of-mouth intentions (Seo et al., 2018), and increasing purchase intentions (McFerran et al., 2010), reviewing the extant literature is critical so that academics are able to not only understand the current state of the field but also advance the field. As such, this systematic literature review synthesizes the literature on *narrative transportation when used as a means of persuasion*.

To address the issues most relevant to marketers who employ narrative transportation as a means by which to communicate and persuade and academics who study narrative transportation in the context of persuasion, we seek to address five questions. First, when studying narrative transportation, what theoretical foundations have provided insights into how narrative transportation persuades (RQ1)? Next, what factors elicit (RQ2), are outcomes of (RQ3), and moderate the effect of (RQ4) narrative transportation? Finally, based on our analysis of the literature, what research questions are left unanswered (RQ5)?

This manuscript is organized as follows. First, we provide an overview of narrative transportation. Second, we discuss the protocol used (Scientific Procedures and Rationales for Systematic Literature Reviews - SPAR-4-SLR; Paul et al., 2021) to obtain our sample. We present our findings, focusing on the relevant theories and concepts (Paul et al., 2021) which enable us to address RQ1–4. We then analyze the results of RQ1–4 to provide insights pertinent to RQ5. In doing so, we provide academics and practitioners with an overview of the current state of the literature, implications from the existing literature, and directions for multiple avenues of future research. Thus, this manuscript can serve as a roadmap for researchers wishing to contribute to the narrative transportation literature.

2 | OVERVIEW OF NARRATIVE TRANSPORTATION

The construct of narrative transportation is grounded in narrative transportation theory and is a process in which an individual becomes absorbed in a story, connecting with the characters and the story environment while simultaneously disconnecting from their physical environment (Green & Brock, 2000). This transportation results in a unique persuasive effect that does not align with traditional dual-processing models (e.g., Elaboration Likelihood Model: Petty et al., 1983). Cognitive effort is relatively high (Nielsen & Escalas, 2010), likely due to the activation of the consumer's imagination (Grigsby et al., 2023), yet counterarguing is less likely to occur (Ma, 2020). The persuasive outcomes that result are also surprisingly long-lasting (Appel & Richter, 2007), despite the apparent lack of careful argument consideration (Lien & Chen, 2013). While narrative transportation has been extensively studied from the perspective of content developed for entertainment purposes (e.g., films: Bezdek & Gerrig, 2017; novels: Gerrig, 1993; TV shows: Pittman & Steiner, 2019), as previously noted,

we are interested specifically in how narrative transportation is used as a persuasive mechanism.

It is important to differentiate narrative transportation from a narrative (an antecedent of narrative transportation) or other processes such as flow or narrative engagement. Please see the Web Appendix S1 for details on how narrative transportation relates to and differs from other process-related constructs. Furthermore, to date, there have been no *systematic* literature reviews on narrative transportation. However, please see the Web Appendix S1 for information on related literature reviews.

3 | METHODOLOGY

Literature reviews, as a research methodology, provide critical insights into a specific area of inquiry and are especially needed when the area of inquiry spans multiple disciplines (Snyder, 2019). We specifically execute a *systematic* literature review as Paul et al. (2021) note that systematic literature reviews, when conducted well, are the most “informative and scientific” (p. 1), resulting in a “product of scholarly research” (p. 2). In doing so, this enables us to address our five primary research questions. To determine our sample, consistent with other systematic literature reviews (Lim et al., 2022), the SPAR-4-SLR protocol was employed (Paul et al., 2021). Following the SPAR-4-SLR protocol, sample articles were selected using three stages, assembling, arranging, and assessing, and their six substages. The stages (and substages) are identified in Figure 1 and detailed in the Web Appendix S1. This process resulted in a final sample of 95 articles (see Web Appendix S1).

4 | RESULTS

Below, we detail our findings as they relate to RQ1–RQ5. To provide additional insights, the Web Appendix S1 also contains a descriptive profiling of our sample.

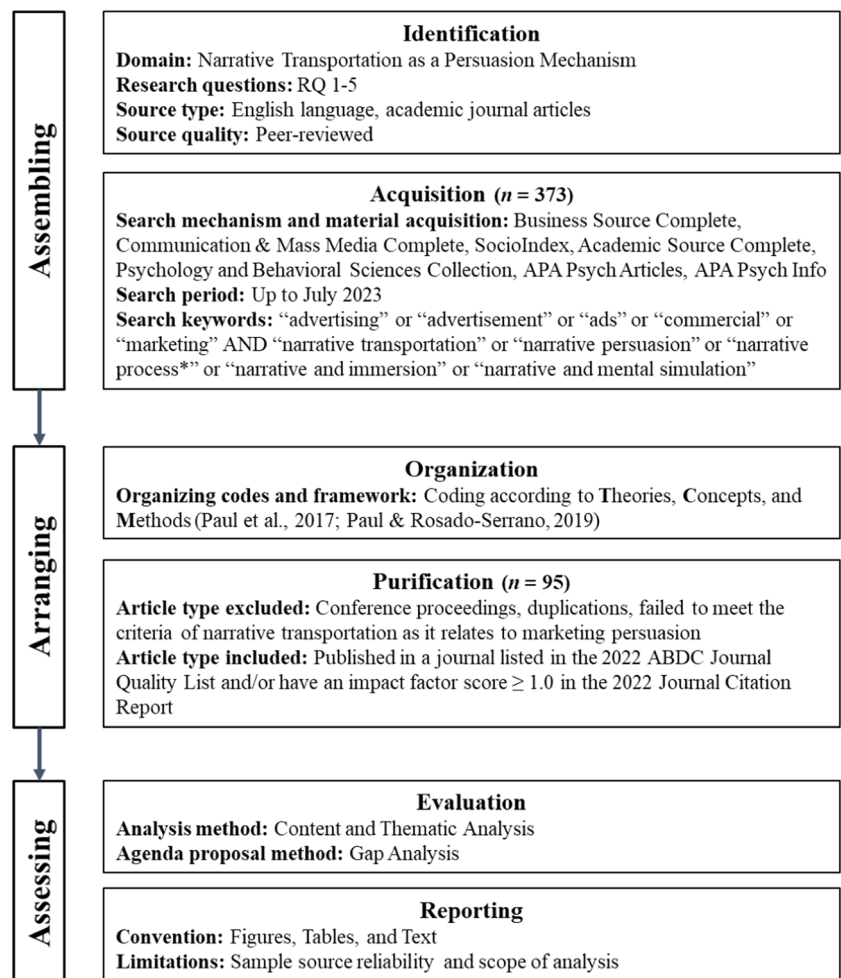
4.1 | Theoretical foundations

Across the literature we reviewed, 14 theories were mentioned in two or more articles, see Table 1. Additionally, 48 other theories were mentioned in just a single article (e.g., protection motivation theory: To & Patrick, 2021; theory of planned behavior: Chou et al., 2022; uses and gratification theory: Sung et al., 2022). Furthermore, some articles employed multiple theories. The theories that were mentioned most frequently are discussed below.

4.1.1 | Narrative transportation theory

Unsurprisingly, the most common theory mentioned was narrative transportation theory ($n = 95$). Narrative transportation theory

FIGURE 1 Sampling methodology. (Paul et., 2017; Paul & Rosado-Serrano, 2019).



typically references Green and Brock (2000), whose research was the first to develop and validate a narrative transportation scale and provide evidence that, through narrative transportation, stories can influence audience beliefs. This finding suggested that stories are uniquely persuasive, and thus narrative transportation theory quickly became popular with marketing academic researchers.

As the theory developed and grew in popularity, different terminology was employed to refer to narrative transportation theory. In the context of advertising, some authors refer to the process through which narrative transportation can influence beliefs as narrative persuasion (e.g., Appel, 2022; Hamby & Brinberg, 2016). Narrative processing is also used interchangeably with narrative transportation (e.g., Bublitz et al., 2016; Hung et al., 2017); it refers to the way consumers process stories (which is encompassed by the original theory: Green & Brock, 2000). When authors use this terminology, they still rely on the same underlying tenets of narrative transportation theory. As such, we counted these articles as relying on narrative transportation theory. We also included the extended transportation-imagery model (van Laer et al., 2014) in this category. This model extends narrative transportation theory to incorporate a more complete set of antecedents, moderators, and consequences (van Laer et al., 2014).

Notably, narrative transportation theory does not explain how or why it is so persuasive. Thus, to elucidate the persuasive process, researchers often integrate narrative transportation theory with other persuasion theories which are discussed in subsequent sections.

4.1.2 | Dual-processing models

This category includes articles that mention the elaboration likelihood model, the heuristic systematic model, or dual-processing theory more generally. Dual-processing theories describe how consumers can process information via two different paths, such as the central or peripheral paths for the elaboration likelihood model (ELM: Petty et al., 1983) or heuristic or systematic processing for the heuristic systematic model (HSM: Chaiken, 1980). Early work (e.g., Escalas, 2004; Green & Brock, 2000) suggested that narrative transportation did not adhere to a traditional dual-processing model. If narrative transportation took the form of processing associated with passive processing (such as the peripheral path of the ELM or heuristic processing of the HSM), then less critical analysis of the message in the story would be expected and resulting attitudes should be weakly held and relatively easy to change. If narrative transportation took the form of processing associated with

TABLE 1 List of theories used in two or more articles in sample.

Theory	Seminal article example article ^a	Count
Narrative transportation theory	Green & Brock (2000) Appel (2022)	95
Dual processing models	Petty et al. (1983) Shaffer et al. (2018)	8
Persuasion knowledge model	Friestad & Wright (1994) Kim (2022)	6
Social cognitive theory	Bandura (2001) Kang et al. (2020)	4
Associative network theory	Collins & Loftus (1975) Avramova et al. (2017)	3
Cognitive capacity theory	Isen & Daubman (1984) Sar & Rodriguez (2019)	2
Entertainment overcoming resistance model	Moyer-Gusă & Nabi (2010) Krakow et al. (2018)	2
Exemplification theory	Zillmann (1999) El-Khoury & Shafer (2016)	2
Identification theory	Cohen, 2018 Dessart (2018)	2
Psychological reactance theory	Brehm (1966) Lillie et al. (2022)	2
Social identity theory	Hogg & Turner (1987) Van den Hende et al. (2012)	2
Taylor's strategy wheel	Taylor (1999) Sharma & Meena (2024)	2

^aThe seminal article represents a well-established article on the noted theory that future researchers can use for source material. The example article is an article from our sample that employs the noted theory.

more active processing (such as the central path of the ELM or systematic processing of the HSM), then more critical thought would be expected and the resulting persuasion that occurred should be long-lasting and more difficult to change (Shaffer et al., 2018). Researchers have found that narrative transportation was associated with a surprising combination of effects. Despite being persuasive, narrative transportation does not appear to involve much critical thought, counterarguing, or analytical processing of the message contained in the story (Escalas, 2004; Shaffer et al., 2018). Researchers have also found that the motivation to process the message, an important antecedent to the ELM, does not influence outcomes when narrative transportation occurs (Huang et al., 2022).

Two reviewed articles examine situations in which narrative transportation can be reduced and consumers will shift their processing approach to better fit in with the predictions made by dual-processing models. Appel (2022) used a manipulative intent warning before showing consumers a story, successfully reducing narrative transportation while eliciting affective resistance to persuasion. Furthermore, Tezer et al. (2022) found that when perceived risk was high, consumers avoided narrative transportation and instead engaged in analytical processing.

4.1.3 | Persuasion knowledge model

The persuasion knowledge model (PKM: Friestad & Wright, 1994) argues that as consumers learn and have consumption experiences, they develop an understanding of common persuasive practices as well as coping strategies to resist the persuasive effects of such tactics. Our review found several instances where the PKM was integrated with narrative transportation. In some cases, cues that activate persuasion knowledge can have a negative influence on persuasive effects, but in other cases, narrative transportation can overcome the negative effects of persuasion knowledge and still be effective.

Perceptions of manipulative intent are one way in which the persuasiveness of stories can be lost (Appel, 2022; Wentzel et al., 2010), as perceptions of manipulative intent reduce narrative transportation. The story format can activate persuasion knowledge in some consumers and, as a result, consumers become skeptical and more critical of the message, reducing its effectiveness (Gilliam & Flaherty, 2015). Similarly, Yıldız and Sever (2022) find that high brand presence in a narrative video ad reduces persuasive outcomes. Other research supports the argument that when consumers feel connected to the brand, message source, or product, narrative transportation will minimize persuasion knowledge effects. For example, the presence of a brand as the source of the message (compared to independent sources such as trade publications) generally increases persuasion knowledge; however, this effect is mitigated when narrative transportation is high (Tezer et al., 2020). Likewise, Feng and colleagues (2021) explore influencer advertising and find that, contrary to expectations, the presence of a sponsorship disclosure label did not significantly influence persuasive outcomes, which the authors attribute to narrative transportation. Kim (2022) finds a similar effect in a pharmaceutical advertising context. When influencers disclosed personal information, persuasion knowledge was reduced, and narrative transportation increased compared to when influencers did not disclose.

4.1.4 | Social cognitive theory

Social cognitive theory states that consumers are most likely to have high self-efficacy concerning a new behavior and more likely to adopt the new behavior when it is demonstrated by an influential peer rather than simply recommended (Bandura, 2001). Because narrative transportation can mimic a real experience due to activation of imagination, empathy, and identification with the story characters, researchers suggest that narratives that depict behaviors (e.g., alcohol consumption: Redondo et al., 2018; domestic violence interventions: El-Khoury & Shafer, 2016; purchase decisions: Kang et al., 2020) can influence consumers to engage in the depicted behaviors. Researchers argue that social cognition may occur as part of the narrative transportation process (e.g., Kang et al., 2020), or it may have a direct influence on consumers regardless of the level of narrative transportation (e.g., Redondo et al., 2018). El-Khoury and Shafer (2016) uncovered a boundary condition such that narrative ads were more effective for those consumers who did not have experience with the behavior.

4.1.5 | Associative network theory

Associative network theory is used to describe how consumers store and access information in memory, suggesting that information is stored in the form of nodes that are connected via links (Collins & Loftus, 1975). New information is stored in memory with related nodes, and during recall, consumers access nodes and related nodes via spreading activation. Researchers argue that associative network theory can work in combination with narrative transportation theory to improve persuasive outcomes. For example, repeated exposure to brand information, whether through repeated mention of an unfamiliar brand (Avramova et al., 2017) or information presented across different media forms (Granitz & Forman, 2015), should improve persuasive outcomes. Narrative transportation, due to reduced counterarguing and increased cognitive effort, further enhances these outcomes (Avramova et al., 2017; Wang & Shen, 2019).

4.2 | Concepts

Given the systematic literature review parameters, every article in our sample discussed either narrative transportation as a theory and/or construct. However, that does not mean that every quantitative manuscript reviewed incorporated narrative transportation as a variable interest. Of the 83 articles that incorporated quantitative methods into some aspect of the study design, 27.7% ($n = 23$) did not formally measure or manipulate narrative transportation. Rather, the literature on narrative transportation provided theoretical support for their conceptualization. As such, the narrative transportation literature was employed to make predictions about related, but distinct constructs such as narrative self-referencing, imagination proclivity, or immersion.

Of the research that included narrative transportation as a construct in the study design ($n = 60$), narrative transportation was almost exclusively measured (98%). Regardless of whether it was manipulated

or measured, narrative transportation was treated as a mediator in 66.7% of the articles, a dependent variable in 11.6% of the articles, an independent variable in 10% of the articles, a moderator in 8.3% of the articles, and an alternative explanation or covariate in 3.3% of the articles. Three of the manuscripts examining narrative transportation did so in the context of scale development (Bennett et al., 2023; Campbell et al., 2023; Yueh & Zheng, 2019), while one examined narrative transportation as an individual difference variable (Brechman & Purvis, 2015).

In Figure 2, we depict the empirical framework, illustrating the overarching relationships examined in our sample. Below we discuss the primary variables of interest and ways in which these variables can be categorized.

4.2.1 | Antecedents

The antecedents of narrative transportation can be classified into three primary categories: storyteller, consumer, and medium characteristics. In a previous review (van Laer et al., 2014), antecedents were classified into two categories: storyteller characteristics and story-receiver characteristics (discussed here as consumer characteristics). Storyteller characteristics include aspects of the story (e.g., plot, brands, etc.) and the characters involved, while consumer characteristics include variables unique to the consumer as opposed to the persuasive information. Medium characteristics include aspects of the medium (e.g., visual, verbal, etc.) that affect transportation. See Table 2 for a complete list of antecedents.

Starting with storyteller characteristics, the most frequently explored antecedent is the narrative nature of the information ($n = 9$), e.g., presenting the information in a story format as compared to an expository (e.g., Wentzel et al., 2010) or list (e.g., Schweitzer & Van den Hende, 2017) format. Presenting information in a story format is more likely to elicit narrative transportation, which is consistent with the prevailing conceptualization that the elements of a story are a

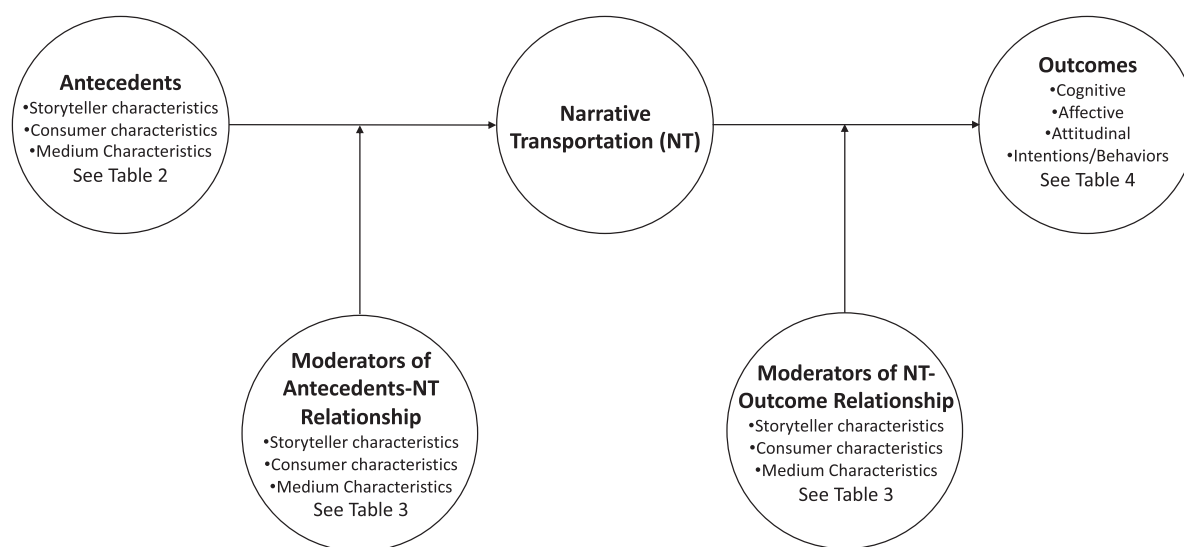


FIGURE 2 Framework of relationships included in review of narrative transportation.

TABLE 2 Antecedents of narrative transportation and their effect^a on narrative transportation.

Storyteller characteristics	
<i>Attributes of the story/information</i>	
Anthropomorphism	+
Disclosure	+
Foreshadowing	+
Guilt appeal	+
Movement in ad	+
Moving music	+
Narrative presentation of information	+
Narrative self-referencing	+
Product-story link	+
<i>Attributes of the brand</i>	
Brand prominence	–
Desirable brand attributes	+
Presence of slogan	+
<i>Attributes of the character</i>	
Averted gaze	+
Narrative perspective	+
Consumer characteristics	
<i>Individual differences</i>	
Age	–
Cognitive flow	+
Education	+
Empathy bias	+
Fantasy proneness	+
Fashion involvement	+
Product expertise/knowledge	+
Technological reflectiveness	+
<i>States</i>	
Character perspective-taking	+
Comprehension	+
Fantasy passport	+
Feelings of enjoyment	+
Imagination	+
Mental simulation	+
<i>Judgments</i>	
Identification with characters/story	+
Perceptions of advertising	+
Perceived contingency	+
Perceptions of spatial presence	+

TABLE 2 (Continued)

Consumer characteristics	
Perceptions of user control	+
Perceived realism	+
Medium Characteristics	
Graphic presentation format	+
Interactivity of information	+
Process demonstration	+

^aThe column on the right signifies whether the effect on narrative transportation was either positive or negative.

necessary, but not sufficient condition of narrative transportation (van Laer et al., 2014). Other attributes of the information (e.g., disclosure: Kim, 2022; movement: Grigsby et al., 2023) are also found to influence narrative transportation. Further, many of the storyteller characteristics can be further classified as attributes specific to the brand (e.g., brand attributes: McFerran et al., 2010; brand placement: Yildiz & Sever, 2022) or attributes of the character (e.g., character gaze: To & Patrick, 2021; narrative perspective: Kim, 2022) that is presented in the persuasive information. These studies identify tactics that marketers can employ to “pull” consumers into the story, enhancing the likelihood that they will be transported.

Consumer characteristics fall into three broad categories: individual differences, states, and judgments. Consumer individual differences include demographic information (e.g., age and education: Neil et al., 2019) and consumer traits (e.g., technological reflectiveness: Schweitzer & Van den Hende, 2017; fantasy proneness: Chen, 2015). Conversely, consumer states, which are temporary, have also been shown to affect narrative transportation and include variables such as imagination (Grigsby et al., 2023), message comprehension (Glaser & Reisinger, 2022), and mental simulation (Escalas, 2004). Finally, consumer judgments include perceptions about user control (Oh et al., 2020), perceived realism (Redondo et al., 2018), and feelings of spatial presence (Ma, 2020). Understanding the effect of consumer characteristics on narrative transportation helps marketers to know who is susceptible to transportation and influences targeting efforts.

Finally, medium characteristics focus on elements of the medium that facilitate or inhibit transportation. The style of a demonstration (Ringler et al., 2024), the ability to interact with the medium (Oh et al., 2020), and the type of medium (Luna-Nevarez, 2021) can influence the extent to which consumers experience narrative transportation. Less research has explored the influence of medium characteristics compared to the other categories we reviewed. We discuss potential areas for research advances related to medium characteristics in Section 5.3.

4.2.2 | Outcomes

The examination of the outcomes of narrative transportation can be broadly viewed as those that are context-general (e.g., beliefs about

helping others: Andrews et al., 2022; personal connections: Anaza et al., 2020) and others that are context-specific¹ (e.g., brand image: Pachucki et al., 2022; story-consistent beliefs: Oh et al., 2020). Furthermore, they can be categorized based on their cognitive, affective, attitudinal, or behavioral effect, see Table 3.

Due to the unique cognitive processing that occurs during narrative transportation, it is perhaps not surprising that many of the outcomes explored are cognitive. Of the 38 unique outcomes explored, 23 (60.5%) fall into the category of cognitive outcomes. Contrast this with only 5 (13.1%) unique outcomes being classified as affective. Many of the cognitive outcomes examined focus on how narrative transportation affects cognitive processing in terms of counterarguing (Ma, 2020), recall (Campbell et al., 2023), and reflection (Hamby & Brinberg, 2016). Additional cognitive outcomes focus on consumers' beliefs (Oh et al., 2020), evaluations (Van den Hende et al., 2012), and perceptions (van Laer, 2014) as the variation in processing that arises from lesser or greater transportation should result in downstream effects on these cognitions. As previously noted, far fewer articles focused on affect. This is interesting as research suggests that while cognitive processing is a critical component to elicit narrative transportation (ultimately leading to the aforementioned cognitive outcomes), empathy or perspective-taking is also necessary (van Laer et al., 2014). While empathy is a precursor to narrative transportation, if one is empathic of the characters in the story and thus transported, affective reactions should be observed. As such, the affective outcomes identified in this literature review, both those related to more general affective states (Hamby & Brinberg, 2016) and more specific affective states (e.g., guilt: Antonetti et al., 2018; joy: Dessart, 2018), are aligned with existing theory on narrative transportation (van Laer et al., 2014) and theory on the reinforcing nature of affect and cognition (e.g., appraisal theory: Scherer, 1999).

Research demonstrates that even when the story has ended, the persuasive effects of narrative transportation often continue (Appel & Richter, 2007). This implies consequences for attitudes and behaviors, both of which were frequently studied outcomes in our sample articles. Attitudes toward the product, brand, and advertisement were frequently measured outcomes that, collectively, were shown to be significantly affected by narrative transportation in 12 different articles. Behavioral intentions specific to the behavior advocated for by the persuasive communication were also frequently examined ($n = 11$) and encompass intentions related to purchases (e.g., Bhatnagar & Wan, 2011), destination visits (Pachucki et al., 2022), prosocial behaviors (e.g., Andrews et al., 2022), and health screenings (e.g., Jensen et al., 2017). Similarly, research also examined intentions to spread word-of-mouth ($n = 4$; Appel, 2022), repurchase (Oh et al., 2020), and seek information (Neil et al., 2019) as well as actual behaviors such as choice (Redondo et al., 2018).

4.2.3 | Moderators

A variety of moderators examine how the effect of an independent variable on narrative transportation can either be attenuated or amplified (see Table 4 for a complete list). Similar to the independent variables, these moderators consider how storyteller, consumer, and medium characteristics change the relationship between antecedents and narrative transportation (left side of Figure 2) or the relationship between narrative transportation and outcomes (right side of Figure 2). Variables on the left side include characteristics of the storyteller (e.g., brand prominence: Yildiz & Sever, 2022; character vulnerability: van Laer et al., 2013), consumer (e.g., belief in luck: McFerran et al., 2010; cognitive load: Wentzel et al., 2010), and medium (e.g., social presence: Ringler et al., 2024). On the right side, variables related to the storyteller include disclosure (Seo et al., 2018) and epilogue presence (Hamby & Brinberg, 2016), while those related to consumer characteristics include self-character similarity (Bhatnagar & Wan, 2011) and tie strength (Seo et al., 2018). Finally, medium characteristics include ad intrusiveness and ad-TV show compatibility (Wang & Calder, 2009). Collectively, these variables explore how narrative transportation affects outcome variables related to consumers' emotions, attitudes, cognitions, and behaviors.

5 | EVOLUTION OF NARRATIVE TRANSPORTATION

These findings illustrate that our understanding and study of narrative transportation has evolved, specifically as it pertains to the story presentation and the antecedents that affect narrative transportation and their interplay. To contextualize this evolution, we discuss and illustrate the model previously employed to understand narrative transportation (Figure 3–Part A, indicated by solid lines). We then modify this framework based on our findings presented in this manuscript—illustrating the present state of the literature (Figure 3–Part A, indicated by dotted lines). Finally, we look toward the future and discuss how we think our understanding of narrative transportation will continue to evolve (Figure 3–Part B). In doing so, we highlight key avenues for future research that will aid in this evolution.

5.1 | The past

Figure 3–Part A illustrates the original narrative transportation model as illustrated via the solid lines (Green & Brock, 2000; van Laer et al., 2014). The narrative transportation process begins with the presence of a story. Traditionally, a story has been conceptualized as having an observable beginning, middle, and end, characters playing roles, and a plot in which unanswered questions or conflicts arise that the characters then work to resolve (Green & Brock, 2000; van Laer et al., 2014). Previous research suggests that a story is a necessary condition for narrative transportation but does not guarantee narrative transportation. Rather, whether and the degree to which

¹These two outcome categories also introduce some measurement issues and inconsistencies that we describe in more detail in the Overview of Methods discussion in the Web Appendix S1.

TABLE 3 Outcomes of narrative transportation and the effect^a of narrative transportation.

Cognitive outcomes	
<i>Cognitive processing</i>	
Ability to enumerate advantages	+
Counterarguing	-
Counterfactual thinking	+
Recall	+
Reflection	+
<i>Evaluations</i>	
Brand evaluations	+
Personal connections	+
Product evaluations	+
Story evaluations	+
<i>Perceptions</i>	
Consumer effectiveness perceptions	+
Escapism perceptions	+
Informational justice perceptions	+
Manipulative intent perceptions	-
Message perceptions	+
Risk perceptions	-
Sense of presence	+
<i>Beliefs</i>	
Acknowledgment of responsibility	+
Beliefs about helping others	+
Brand image	+
Brand trust	+
Product expectations	+
Reactance	-
Story-consistent beliefs	+
Affective outcomes	
Anticipated guilt	+
Brand-evoked affect	+
Joy	+
Negative affect	-
Positive affect	+
Attitudinal outcomes	
Attitude toward ad	+
Attitude toward brand	+
Attitude toward product	-
Behavioral intentions and behavioral outcomes	
Behavioral intentions	+
Information seeking intentions	+

TABLE 3 (Continued)

Behavioral intentions and behavioral outcomes	
Parasocial interactions	+
Product choice	+
Repurchase intentions	+
Willingness to respond/help	+
Word of mouth intentions	+

^aThe column on the right signifies whether the effect of narrative transportation was either positive or negative.

an individual is transported depends on antecedents that can be classified into two categories: storyteller characteristics and consumer characteristics.

5.2 | The present

We now formally propose the present state of the narrative transportation model. The elements of the conceptual model depicted in Figure 3–Part A, shown with the dotted lines, are driven by the findings from our systematic literature review and illustrate how academics' conceptualization of narrative transportation has evolved. First, what constitutes a story has shifted. While the definition of a story (as noted above) has not changed, our findings suggest that researchers now realize that stories can take new forms. For example, relatively small adjustments to copy, such as Escalas's (2004) "imagine yourself in the product," or the image (e.g., movement: Grigsby et al., 2023; eye gaze: To & Patrick, 2021; profile picture poses: Farace et al., 2017) can generate narrative transportation. Essentially, consumers do not need all the elements of a story presented to them (this is visually depicted by the dotted lines around the box that contains "STORY"). Rather, tactics, like the ones noted, prompt consumers to generate the less explicit story elements. The story, though, while not complete, is still heavily guided by the marketer. The tactics used to encourage additional elaboration are presented to the consumer in conjunction with carefully crafted images and messages. Thus, when consumers become transported, it is still into a world of the marketer's making, not the consumer's design.

Second, our findings highlight the role of the medium and its characteristics as a nascent antecedent of narrative transportation. The study of narrative transportation originated with written (i.e., novels, blog posts) or filmed (i.e., movies, TV shows) stories and, as persuasive communications (i.e., TV commercials) employed these same formats, the examination of narrative transportation in the context of marketing did not initially give much consideration to potential effects elicited by the medium being used. However, our findings illustrate that marketers are expanding the boundaries of how consumers experience stories. As such, researchers have started to examine storytelling through less traditional media: social media (Feng et al., 2021), virtual reality (Ma, 2020), and product demonstrations (Ringler et al., 2024). This recognition of a third category (medium characteristics) adds nuance to the framework and

TABLE 4 Moderators examined in relation to narrative transportation.

Moderators influencing the relationship between the IV and narrative transportation	Moderators influencing the relationship between narrative transportation and the DV
Storyteller characteristics	
<i>Attributes of the story/information</i>	<i>Attributes of the story/information</i>
Ad appeal	Disclosure
Information presentation order	Epilogue presence
	Narrative nature of information
<i>Attributes of the brand</i>	<i>Attributes of the brand</i>
Brand congruence	Organizational status
Brand luxury status	Package congruence
Brand prominence	Product type
<i>Attributes of the character</i>	<i>Attributes of the character</i>
Character type	
Character vulnerability	
Humanization	
Consumer characteristics	
<i>Individual differences</i>	<i>Individual differences</i>
Belief in luck	
Need for cognitive closure	
<i>States</i>	<i>States</i>
Cognitive load	
<i>Judgments</i>	<i>Judgments</i>
Character similarity	Character similarity
Perceptions of manipulative intent	Tie strength
Medium characteristics	
Social presence	Ad position
	Ad-TV show compatibility

Note: Blank spaces indicate no moderators have been investigated in this category and highlight opportunities for future research.

provides opportunities to compare the effectiveness of different media at eliciting narrative transportation. This remains an underexplored area in the current state of the narrative transportation literature.

5.3 | The future

5.3.1 | The framework

We believe that the narrative transportation model will continue to evolve (see Figure 3–Part B) and that future research can aid in this evolution. Immersive and interactive new technologies, such as

virtual and augmented reality and Artificial Intelligence (AI), will shape how stories are presented to consumers (see Dwivedi et al., 2023 for an in-depth discussion on the metaverse and consumer research). We posit that technology will facilitate the development of stories that do not have a set story structure. This is represented by the visual depiction of the story's integration with the antecedents of narrative transportation in Figure 3–Part B. Specifically, the narrative transportation framework should account for the occurrence of stories that will be co-created, developed through the consumers' interactions with the medium and as a character in their own story. The story will no longer be controlled by the marketer but will constantly morph and look distinctly different for each consumer.

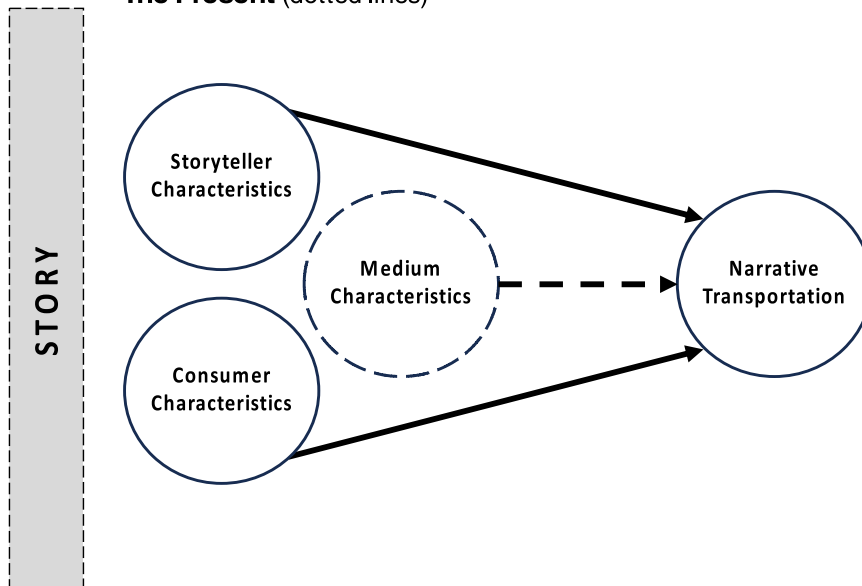
While characteristics of the storyteller, consumer, and medium will continue to directly affect narrative transportation, new technology will blur the lines between the storyteller, consumer, and medium, resulting in joint effects of these characteristics on narrative transportation. Immersive technologies will make it so that the consumer and the storyteller can easily be one and the same. Instead of watching a character's story unfold, the consumer will be the character. Consumers will also now be active as opposed to passive participants of the medium, and the boundary between the medium and the consumer will become less distinct. Rather than the medium dictating how the story unfolds (as in a traditional movie or print story), the consumer will make decisions about how they decide to move through the medium (e.g., virtual reality, augmented reality, immersive environments, story prompts provided to AI interfaces). The consumer may also begin to feel like the medium is an extension of their own physical body, such as when a virtual hand begins to feel like one's own hand (i.e., the sense of embodiment: Kilteni et al., 2012), or an extension of their personal identity such as in the case of an avatar (Belk, 2024; Hadi et al., 2024). The consumer may also be shaped by the medium; research has found that avatar characteristics can influence how a consumer behaves in a virtual world (i.e., the Proteus effect, Mal et al., 2023). Furthermore, the medium and story will interact in unexplored ways. For example, AI-integrated technology will result in new ways in which the story will unfold. And, finally, all these elements (storyteller, consumer, and medium characteristics) will become integrated in ways that have yet to be explored, contributing to novel elicitations of narrative transportation.

5.3.2 | Areas of inquiry

This next iteration of the narrative transportation framework provides numerous avenues for future research.² See Table 5 for a

²As researchers explore this evolution of narrative transportation, we encourage them to consult the literature on immersion in the context of video games. Immersion is not the same as narrative transportation. However, it is important to note that the term has been defined with great inconsistencies (e.g., Agrawal et al., 2020). While not the same, findings from this stream of research may provide additional insights (see Agrawal et al., 2020 for a review).

Part A—The Past (solid lines; Green & Brock, 2000; van Laer et al., 2014)
The Present (dotted lines)



Part B—The Future (dotted lines)

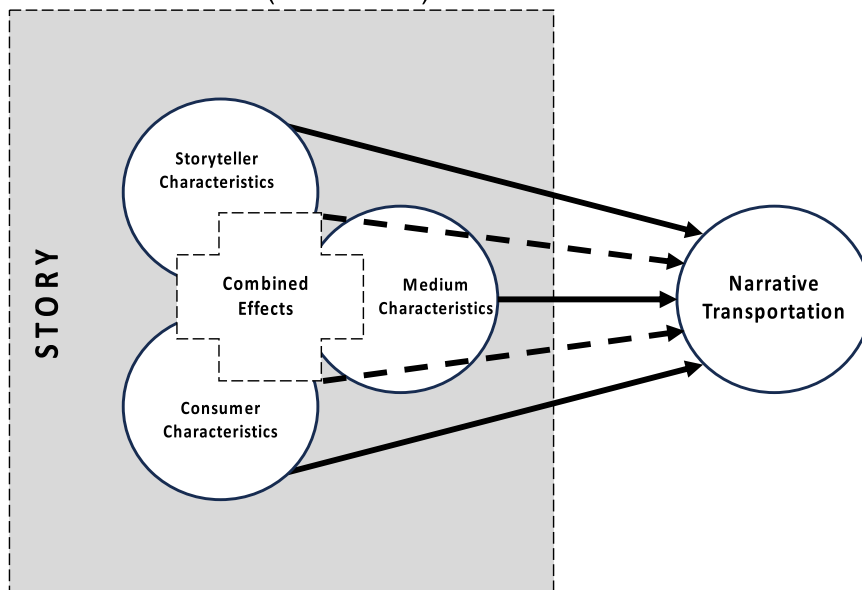


FIGURE 3 The evolution of the narrative transportation framework.

summary of these research questions which are labeled (Future Research – FR) to connect the table to the corresponding text. Regarding story construction, research is needed on how consumers' construction of their own storylines affects previously explored outcomes (FR 1). As the story is driven by the consumer's action, it will be distinct for each consumer, potentially affecting thoughts, feelings, and behaviors in new ways. Thus, literature on value co-creation, whereby the consumer plays an active role in creating the value that they derive from a consumption experience (Ranjan & Read, 2016), will be critical to understanding how consumers respond to and transport through these new story worlds that are of their own making. This evolution of the story format provides opportunities for researchers to investigate consumer traits (FR 2) and

marketing cues (FR 3) that trigger consumers to engage in story development. Sensory marketing (Krishna & Schwarz, 2014), which has yet to be fully explored in the context of narrative transportation, may shed light on how consumers use their bodily feelings as a source of information to engage with and write their own stories. Furthermore, marketers will want to understand how, if at all, they can guide the direction of consumers' story creation, particularly as it pertains to the technology that facilitates the transportation process and with which consumers interact, e.g., chatbots. The Computers-Are-Social-Actors Paradigm and literature on parasocial relationships may be of use as the former suggests that consumers treat technology as social entities, applying social norms to such interactions (Nass et al., 1994), and the latter finds that consumers can

TABLE 5 Potential questions for future research.

Story evolution	
FR 1	How does the consumers' active engagement in developing a story (e.g., determining how to further the plot, ability to choose which characters to interact with, deciding on which of their own goals they want to fulfill through this story) affect their cognitive processing, emotional reactions, and brand connections?
FR 2	What consumer traits (e.g., creativity, need for cognition) influence narrative development?
FR 3	What marketing cues (e.g., use of human v. animal v. alien characters, realistic v. fantasy worlds) trigger consumers to elaborate upon the communication as though it were a story?
Consumer characteristics-storyteller characteristics overlap	
FR 4	How does a consumer's dual role as consumer and storyteller affect their cognitive processing, emotional reactions, and brand connections?
FR 5	How do consumers interact with brand-generated story characters (e.g., are they treated as equals, subservient, and/or are relationships formed)?
FR 6	How do consumers cocreate the narrative with other consumers who are storytellers (e.g., how are decisions made regarding the direction of the story, roles established, etc.)?
Consumer characteristics-medium characteristics overlap	
FR 7	Given consumer individual differences are certain mediums more likely to elicit negative reactions (e.g., reactance, persuasion knowledge)?
FR 8	How does integrating aspects of the medium with the consumer's body (e.g., wearable devices) detract from or facilitate the transportation experience and relationship with the wearable device brand?
FR 9	How does integrating aspects of the medium with the consumer's body affect consumers' physical well-being in unique ways due to the narrative transportation experience (e.g., perceptions of fatigue, injury)?
Storyteller characteristics-medium characteristics overlap	
FR 10	Which media are more effective at shaping consumers' attitudes toward brands featured in the story?
FR 11	How do sensory capabilities (e.g., VR haptic interfaces) influence how stories can be told?
Consumer characteristics-storyteller characteristics-medium characteristics overlap	
FR 12	How do consumers make sense of their own autonomy, the storyteller's autonomy, and the collective integration with the medium?
FR 13	How does the consumer, as a main character in an immersive reality, influence their perceptions of reality and life satisfaction?
FR 14	To what extent does this transportation experience bleed into consumers' daily lives (i.e., do consumers leave these experiences more changed regarding their mental/affective states, interactions with others, etc.)?

develop relationships with virtual entities (Stein et al., 2022). Collectively, this suggests that digital entities may elicit transportation and encourage the development of storylines.

New areas of inquiry arise as consumer, storyteller, and medium characteristics start to overlap (note: we still contend that the direct effects of these three characteristics will remain). When consumers become the characters central to the story (i.e., they are now both the consumer and the storyteller), it is unclear how previously explored antecedents categorized as storyteller characteristics could affect the narrative transportation process and relevant outcomes (FR 4). For individuals willing to engage with these new media,³

transportation may be elicited with greater ease due to the consumer's level of involvement as well as greater processing fluency, defined as the ease with which an individual engages in the mental processing of a stimulus, such as a story (Schwarz, 2004). However, while traditional wisdom suggests increased fluency could amplify the effectiveness of established antecedents, some research (e.g., Bhatnagar & Wan, 2011; Nielsen & Escalas, 2010) finds increased fluency could negatively influence outcomes. Outcomes may also be amplified, especially consumers' affective reactions, which, as previously noted, have been less explored. Rather than feeling empathy for the character, the consumer as a character has their own emotional reactions. Indeed, emotional flow theory proposes that consumers naturally experience varying emotions as they process a message (Fitzgerald et al., 2023). Given that consumers perceive that the story is happening to them as opposed to a character who they are observing, consumers' emotional states may be more intensified and elicit stronger reactions toward the story elements.

³Underscoring the impact of novel media on the narrative transportation process, we recognize that individual differences will significantly influence consumers' desire to participate in this new form of transportation (FR 7). This highlights the overlap between consumer and medium characteristics. The Technology Acceptance Model (Davis, 1989), reactance theory (Brehm, 1966), and the persuasion knowledge model (Friestad & Wright, 1994) may provide important insights for future research as these theories explore consumer receptiveness to technology, reactions to perceived threats to freedom, and efforts to cope with persuasion attempts, respectively.

As previously noted, characters in the story may prompt story development. However, understanding how consumers engage with these characters is also of interest (FR 5). Furthermore, as narrative transportation is an individualized process, the role of others (e.g., watching a movie with a friend) has been acknowledged but not thoroughly examined. What research exists finds mixed effects of co-viewing on consumers' ability to experience transportation (Ringler et al., 2024; Tal-Or, 2016). Media is evolving to more readily incorporate multiple consumers as human characters. These consumers may have their own goals for the narrative, influencing how others experience narrative transportation. This highlights how the overlap between consumer, storyteller, and medium characteristics is more pronounced in the next iteration of the narrative transportation framework. For example, Wander is a VR exploration app that enables users to teleport to almost any place in the world. Users have the option to explore with other unknown consumers or friends. In this case, other consumers are not bystanders but active participants in telling the story. Future research should explore how the presence of unknown and known others influences consumers' ability to transport and the reflective assessment of the transportation experience and brands involved (FR 6). For example, does running through the streets of Rome on the Wander app acting out a narrative connect consumers more with their fellow characters and, ultimately, the brand (i.e., Rome)? In addition to providing managerial insights, these new avenues will inform theory on how consumers connect with and influence one another (e.g., social identity theory: Hogg & Turner, 1987) and how consumers establish relationships with brands (e.g., brand relationships theory: Fournier, 1998).

Finally, as the medium (e.g., wearable devices) becomes more integrated with the consumer, questions arise regarding how this affects their transportation experience as consumers may be more cognizant of a wearable device as compared to traditional transportation methods, e.g., TV (FR 8). Furthermore, does the integration of a device affect physical well-being (FR 9), altering perceptions of fatigue or injury? Similarly, the device's sensory capabilities (medium characteristics) and storyteller characteristics may work in tandem to shape and reinforce narratives. Some devices may have a more synergistic effect with storyteller characteristics, providing elevated story experiences and reinforcing brand narratives and consumer attitudes (FR 10). As devices become more sophisticated, the use of physiological responses can also be employed to assess consumer states and aspects of the story can be modified accordingly (FR 11). For example, a device that detects an elevated heart rate during a VR wartime game can adjust the storyline to provide the consumer with a break from the action.

At a more abstract level, the synergistic effect of all characteristics (consumer, storyteller, and medium) may lead to broader questions about how consumers situate themselves within reality and the bleed they experience from their transportation experiences. Questions pertaining to how consumers reflect on their own sense of autonomy (FR 12), as well as experience life satisfaction (FR 13) outside of these transportive experiences, arise. Furthermore, exploring potential changes pertaining to consumers' mental well-

being (i.e., self-esteem, regret) due to these experiences is incredibly important (FR 14).

6 | CONCLUSION

Since the last review of the literature (van Laer et al., 2014), substantial contributions have been made to the narrative transportation literature. Most strikingly, prior reviews identified two primary categories of antecedents (storyteller and consumer characteristics); in this review, we find that researchers have started to explore medium characteristics as antecedents to narrative transportation. However, medium characteristics remain relatively unexplored and invite additional research. Furthermore, we also update the specific variables (and the directionality of their effects) that have been introduced and explored pertaining to storyteller and consumer characteristics. This review also synthesizes the moderating and outcome variables that have been examined. We find that affective responses were a relatively unexplored area, as were moderators related to attributes of the character, individual differences, and consumer mental states. We also detail the primary theories employed, which has not been previously done in prior reviews. Collectively, this synthesis of the literature should enable researchers to have a holistic understanding of the narrative transportation literature and enable them to more readily develop research questions that focus on novel relationships.

This review also contributes to understanding the theoretical evolution of narrative transportation. By identifying key technological trends with the impetus to shape consumers' story experiences and, ultimately, their transportation process, we lay the groundwork for the next stage of narrative transportation research. We make three key contributions with our updated framework (Figure 3–Part B). We propose that (1) the definition of a story will continue to evolve as consumers become more involved in the story co-creation process, (2) the construction of co-created stories will involve contributions made by the consumer, storyteller, and medium, and (3) this evolving and dynamic story development process involving the storyteller, consumer, and medium will influence narrative transportation in new and unexpected ways. This framework illustrates opportunities to integrate narrative transportation research with divergent theories like the computers-are-social-actors paradigm, sensory marketing, and the technology acceptance model. Exploring this proposed framework will shape our understanding of narrative transportation in the dynamic and growing ecosystem of consumer technology.

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SUPPORTING INFORMATION

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